Whether this is true, that Akbar took his first human life in Panipat, or whether, as is more generally believed, it was Bairam who finally swung his own sword in an impatient arc and cut off Hemu's head, the fact is that Akbar's official history overflows with regret for Hemu's death. 'Would that [the emperor] had come out of his veil,' writes Abul Fazl; would that Akbar had forbidden Hemu's execution and inducted him into his own service instead. A man of such 'lofty spirit' under Akbar's patronage, 'what works might he not have performed?'

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Thus, at any rate, the Second Battle of Panipat was won, but Hemu was hardly the only challenge that Akbar and Bairam faced during these first months of what was, in effect, their joint reign. Back in Badakhshan, Sulaiman – seniormost in the family after his cousin Humayun's death – had taken over neighbouring fiefs while their holders were in Hindustan,[46] and besieged Kabul, where he was held at bay by Munim Khan for several months until Sulaiman retreated in September 1556, only weeks before Tardi Beg lost Delhi. The intrepid Ali Quli Shaibani's brother, Bahadur Khan, had made a move on Qandahar, forcing its Mughal governor to seek Persian help. As is only too likely to happen when flies invite spiders home, Qandahar surrendered, some months later, not to Bahadur but to the mighty Shah Tahmasp, chafing, no doubt, ever since Humayun swiped the city from under his nose. Closer home, a former governor of Sher Shah Suri's, Hajji Khan, had commandeered Narnaul, south-west of Delhi, and marched upon Alwar.

It was in pursuit of Hajji Khan that Pir Muhammad, Bairam's deputy, now set off. En route, he found Hemu's wife, fleeing with 'elephants laden with gold'.[47] The widow who might have been queen managed to escape, but her elephants and riches fell to the Mughals, the neighbouring villagers, and the ground – there was so much gold that they were picking it up by the shield-full, writes Badauni; years later, lucky travellers might still find 'gold coins and ingots' along the way.

Understandably, the loot delayed Pir Muhammad, and Hajji Khan had long escaped when the Mughal army reached Alwar. Pir Muhammad had, in any case, found himself a more tempting and remunerative target: he rode